

CHAPTER 2

HOMER, HESIOD, *and* GREEK LYRIC POETRY

This book will traverse nearly a thousand years of literature, law, history, and art. During such a long period of time (covering two major cultures), the reader must expect that attitudes and ideas about sex will have changed considerably. Unfortunately, my investigations are hampered by some of the same difficulties that also affect investigations into modern sexual practice. Although the Greeks and Romans were in some ways much less concerned about obscenity than the modern West, at other times they seem hesitant to talk about specific sexual acts. Just as when dealing with current events, then, the researcher must sometimes read between the lines.

Further affecting this inquiry, moreover, is the fact that we do not have a full record of sources for every time period under investigation. Often we have, essentially, only one. Thus, for the Archaic period in Greece (dating from roughly 800–500 BCE), the primary sources consist of a body of heroic, didactic, and erotic poetry. The last century of this period also produced some painted vases having to do with same-sex and opposite-sex love, which I will treat in a later chapter. History, in the modern sense of the word, had not been invented yet. For the Classical period (500–340 BCE), a new set of sources emerge: the comedies of Aristophanes, the philosophy of Plato, and a set of legal speeches that sometimes deal with sexual matters.

Because the kinds of sources that remain are different for different periods, it is difficult to know if what appears to be a historical difference—for example, an increase in concern with heteroerotic romantic love—is due to an actual change in attitude or simply to the kind of sources that remain to us from that period. It is almost impossible to talk about sexuality in Archaic Greek law, for example, because we do not have any Archaic Greek legal speeches (though we do have the texts of some laws that are said to come from the Archaic period).

In this chapter, I discuss the evidence for sexual attitudes and practice in the Archaic period. As will become evident, all of my sources are poetic. Even within this limited set of data, the kind of poetry matters: in the love poetry of Anacreon, sex is a primary concern. A different kind of evidence is presented by the heroic epic of Homer, which represents an earlier oral poetic tradition. The shifts in emphasis from Homer to Anacreon do not necessarily indicate a historical change in sexual practice; they are probably the result of the separate requirements of different kinds of poetry. As a result we must take care when using poetry as an indication of sexual practice in the real world at any given time. Nonetheless, this is the evidence that exists, and my strategy is to make the most of it.

What is particularly striking about the poetry from this period is that even when the works in question describe sexual desire in explicit terms, none of the poets discussed in this chapter seem to be concerned with the question of sexual orientation. Nearly all the erotic poetry from the Archaic period presumes a masculine subject of desire, who may be interested in sex with either young men or women. Sappho is a notable exception because her poetry often takes the narrative voice of a desiring woman, but even in her case, the question of which gender constitutes an appropriate object seems of greater concern to us than to her. In other words, Archaic Greece does not give evidence of *sexuality* in the modern sense of the word. It does, however, provide striking examples of anxiety about the proper behavior of lovers and beloveds, within the roles of penetrating and penetrated, as discussed in chapter 1.

For the most part, this chapter is arranged chronologically. Homer and Hesiod are the earliest of the poets that I discuss, and Anacreon and Theognis, who follow, are roughly contemporary. Sappho is somewhat earlier than Anacreon and Theognis (though later than Homer and Hesiod), but I have reserved her for the end of the chapter because it will be easier to understand her poetry once we have considered the predominantly male lyric poets with whom she shares both genre and general time period.

SEX IN THE HOMERIC EPICS

The texts of Homer's *Iliad* and *Odyssey* are little short of miraculous. Though they appear in the eighth or seventh centuries BCE, they contain mythic material from a period some 500 years earlier. In the modern era, Milman Parry showed definitively that these were the products of oral poetry; that is, they were composed and transmitted only in spoken form for some hundreds of years before attaining their current, written state. In

a real sense, then, these epics have no single author, and even the name “Homer” cannot be identified with a particular individual who lived at a particular time and wrote these works; rather, “Homer” is the name traditionally assigned to the poems as they were transmitted in canonical form to the Greeks of Archaic and Classical periods. Almost every aspect of this transmission is the subject of lively scholarly debate. It is also important for our purposes, however, because of the difficulty that it presents in discussing so-called Homeric society.

In brief, there is no easy way to determine how historical the epics are. If, as some scholars think, they preserve accurate depictions of social institutions (marriage, law, inheritance), there is little agreement as to what era those social institutions come from. Are they from the time of the poem’s setting, in the 1200s BCE? Or from the time of the poet, in the 750s BCE? Or somewhere in between? I have become convinced that the poems primarily reflect the society and conventions of Homer’s own day, which is to say, the eighth century BCE. It is almost certain, however, that no actual person ever lived under a society exactly as Homer describes it.¹ His is a poetic and heroic world, often depicting an upper-class ideal. We must assume that many aspects of real life are simply not depicted in Homer, just as we would not take a modern action film as presenting documentary truth.

That said, the only sexual activity referred to in the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* is clearly heteroerotic. There are no explicit descriptions of sex, though some characters do go to bed together, and we do hear occasionally that they enjoyed each other’s company in this way. But more important, the conflict that causes the Trojan War is that between the Greek king Menelaos and the Trojan prince Paris. Paris has stolen away Menelaos’s wife, Helen, who is the most beautiful woman in the world. As a result, Menelaos, his brother, Agamemnon, and the other kings of Greece unite in an expedition to bring her back. Subplots have the same structure: Agamemnon and Achilles fight over who should possess Briseis, a young woman captured from the Trojans.

Helen is a particularly problematic character in this story, and one whose alliances and affections are not always easy to discern. Her beauty is her defining characteristic, and it holds a terrible force for those who see it.² Neither the poet nor the characters in the *Iliad* ever describe Helen physically, beyond a few stock adjectives (she is blonde and lovely-armed). Instead, we see the reaction of people who look on her. In book 3, for example, Helen appears on the walls of Troy. This is in the 10th year of the war, and Troy has suffered greatly because of her presence there. Here is how the old men of Troy see her:

These men, when they saw Helen approaching the tower,
gently counseled one another with winged words:
“There is no blame for the Trojans and the strong-greaved Achaeans,
for suffering sorrows for a long time over such a woman as this;
she seems, in her face, dreadfully like an immortal goddess;
but even though she is such, let her go away on the ships
lest she be left behind, a grief to us and our children in the future.”
(*Iliad* 3.154–160)³

Helen’s appearance is frightening in the sense that it drives men to do crazy things, even when they know that they would be better off not to. She compels the Trojans, quite literally, to “suffer hardship” on behalf of her beauty.

This beauty is Helen, and it gives her a form of power that is unmatched by other women in literature, even extremely beautiful ones. In a later poem known as the *Catalogue of Women*, ascribed to Hesiod (but probably dating to 100 or more years later than Homer), the poet tells us the story of the princes of Greece wooing Helen before she was wed. Throughout the *Catalogue of Women*, there are stories of men marrying women, and the formulaic phrase describing their aspirations is “and he made her his blooming bride.” In the story of the suitors of Helen, however, the relative power of groom and bride is reversed. Over and over again, we read a new formula: “for greatly he wished in his spirit to be the husband of lovely-haired Argive Helen.” A man can make another woman his wife, but Helen’s beauty is such that whoever marries her will become her husband. (This story, in fact, is the only place in the *Catalogue of Women* where the word *husband* appears.)

The most sexually explicit scene in the *Iliad*, and the only sex scene between mortals, occurs between Paris and Helen. In book 3, Paris engages in single combat with Menelaos, and he does not fare well. As he is on the verge of losing, Paris is whisked out of battle by Aphrodite, the goddess of lust and attraction. She takes him to Helen’s bedroom, pretties him up, and more or less forces Helen to sleep with him. Paris, here, is clearly beautiful himself. But it is also worth noting that his preference for love over the manly arts of war makes him a bit less than fully masculine. Helen initially tries to dismiss him:

You have come back from the battle. It would have been better for
you to die there,
mastered by the stronger man, who was my husband before.
Indeed, you used to boast that you were better

than war-loving Menelaos in strength, and with your hand and spear.
But go now, call war-loving Menelaos
to fight opposite you again; but no, I at least advise you
to stop, and not to battle strong battles with
fair-haired Menelaos, nor to fight with him,
thoughtlessly, lest you should be somehow beaten down swiftly by his
spear. (*Iliad* 3.428–436)

Helen seems torn, here, between her disgust for Paris, who has proven himself less than a man, and her attraction to him. She does not, after all, want him to be so brave that he dies. Similarly, when Hektor, Paris's brother and the leader of the Trojans, arrives in book 6, he can hardly believe that Paris is lying around with his wife, rather than fighting the enemy:

But Hektor saw him and rebuked him with shameful words:
You, inhuman, it is not proper that you hold this anger in your heart;
the people are dying around the city and the sheer wall
fighting, and because of you, the clang and battle
has blazed around this city. But you would fight with any other,
whom you saw somehow holding back from the hateful war.
But get up, so that our city does not swiftly burn in the flaming blaze.
(*Iliad* 6.325–331)

Manliness, here as often in the idealizing pages of Greek literature, requires bravery in the forefront of battle, not dillydallying with beautiful women.

Even if Paris is a little bit less than a man, however, he does engage in sex with Helen, and there are no clear suggestions of men desiring other men in this epic. Can we say, then, that the *Iliad* shows us a clear heterosexual ethic? Not quite yet. In the first place, it is worth noting that here, as in much of later Greek literature, the poet presents a hero who is particularly attractive to women, but who is not, on that account, considered particularly manly. In fact, Paris's attractiveness to Helen, and his tendency to be with her rather than out on the field of battle, suggests that he is somewhat effeminate. Rather than being a sign of masculinity, spending too much time with women could have been taken as a failure of manhood, of being womanish.

Even more important, however, there is one other deeply emotional and affective relationship in the epic, and that is the heroic friendship between Achilles and his companion and double Patroklos. When Achilles, angry at Agamemnon, refuses to fight for the Greeks, it is Patroklos who

keeps in touch with the troops and reports back. When the Greeks are in dire straits, Patroklos urges Achilles to loan him his armor so that he can scare the Trojans and win some breathing space for the Greek troops. And finally, when Hektor kills Patroklos, Achilles lets go of his grudge against Agamemnon and rejoins the fray to recover Patroklos's body. It is his relationship to Patroklos, finally, that acts as a kind of social glue, bringing Achilles back into the group of heroes who are his peers.

Though the two heroes are never shown in any kind of physical intimacy—and at night, we are told, they lie in separate beds, each with a woman by his side—they are emotionally bound to one another. When Patroklos requests to borrow Achilles's armor, Achilles expresses a wish that only he and Patroklos might survive the war together (*Iliad* 16.97–99). After Patroklos has died, Achilles's mother (the minor goddess Thetis) comes to him and tries to ease his grief and convince him not to reenter the battle. She tells him that if he does enter battle again, he will win great fame, but is fated to die soon. A distraught Achilles responds,

My mother, the Olympian god has accomplished these things for me;
but what pleasure is there for me from these? Since my dear companion
has died,
Patroklos, whom I loved beyond all companions,
as much as my own life. I lost him, and Hektor, having slain him, has
stripped away
the mighty armor, amazing to look at. . . .
But now, there must be for you numberless grief in your heart
for your son, dying, whom you will not receive again
having returned to his own home, since my spirit does not urge me
to live, nor to remain among men, unless Hektor
first, struck down by my spear should lose his life,
and pay the penalty for Patroklos, son of Menoitios. (*Iliad* 18.79–93)

In rejecting Thetis's advice, Achilles fully realizes that he is giving himself over to death; he really does love Patroklos more than himself.

Achilles, however, still has something to learn about desire and its unfulfilled nature. After Patroklos has died and Achilles has killed Hektor in an act of brutal violence, he finds that revenge is ultimately unsatisfying, that it cannot replace his lost friend:

But Achilles
wept, remembering his dear companion, and sleep did not
come to him, sleep that subdues all; rather, he was twisting and turning

full of longing for Patroklos, for his manhood and great strength,
and for all he contrived, and the pains he suffered together with him,
wars of men and crossing over the sorrowful waves;
remembering these things he poured down swollen tears
now lying on his side, another time again
on his back, then again prone. (*Iliad* 24.3–11)

It is not too much to say that Achilles here is acting much as we expect unrequited lovers to behave in films and stories today. He constantly thinks of his lost friend, wishes that Patroklos were still alive, and is himself unable to eat or sleep in his longing. Achilles's friendship with Patroklos is, in these terms, the strongest emotional bond in the entire epic.

Does that, however, make Achilles and Patroklos lovers? This is a question that has been raised, and contemplated, from the Classical period in Greece to the present day. Though the argument has been made that they are lovers, I must say that there is no evidence in the text for a physical relationship between the two heroes; rather, their friendship falls into that somewhat anomalous category of male-male relationships that persists in the West today, particularly in conditions of intense competition such as war.

What is particularly interesting about the story of Patroklos and Achilles, though, is that in the fifth century in Athens, it appears that the natural assumption was that the two heroes were lovers. In a legal speech that we will look at in more detail later, the speaker (a professional orator named Aeschines) argues that Homer hides their love for one another, "thinking that the greatness of their affection would be apparent to those of the listeners who were educated" (Aeschines *Against Timarchos* 142). Aeschylus, the great Athenian playwright, wrote a tragedy in which the two were portrayed as lovers. But as Plato points out in the *Symposium* (180a4–7), Aeschylus seems to have gotten their sexual roles wrong. Aeschylus portrayed Achilles as the lover, that is, the *erastes*. But as Homer makes clear, Patroklos is the older of the two and so, under the pederastic system of the fifth century in Athens, should have been the lover and Achilles the *eromenos*, or beloved.

All of this demonstrates a simple fact, which is that each society tends to read the *Iliad* with its own cultural assumptions in mind. For most European and American scholars working in the twentieth century, the two heroes were not, and could not be lovers. The idea of presenting a gay Achilles is, to say the least, a bit subversive. But to the Greeks of the fifth century, it is clear that they must have been lovers, even if they did not seem to fit into the pederastic model that was the cultural norm in Classi-

cal Athens. Ultimately, the question of whether or not these two fictional characters were lovers is both unanswerable and, perhaps, irrelevant. What matters most is the way in which this fundamental text elicits the unspoken assumptions of its readers.

HESIOD AND THE FIRST WOMAN

Like Homer, Hesiod is less a person whom we can identify than a name attributed to a set of poetry from the early Archaic period. Unlike the heroic epics that Homer is known for, however, Hesiod is best known for a poem describing the origins of the Greek gods, called the *Theogony*, and a didactic poem about farming and justice, called the *Works and Days*. Perhaps the most famous passage in Hesiod's work is the story about the creation of the first woman on earth; this story appears in both the *Theogony* and the *Works and Days*, though in slightly different form in each.

Myths of origin always provide insight into the ways in which people were thinking when the myth was created (or retold), and the story of the first woman is no exception. As a paradigm for how the Greeks thought about gender and sexual difference, then, the story of Pandora is particularly valuable. In the *Theogony*, this first woman (who is not named in this version) is given to humankind as a punishment. It seems that the god Prometheus, who generally rivals Zeus in mythical texts, has tricked the chief Olympian god twice, both times in ways that benefit humankind. Zeus's revenge is to create a woman, who is described explicitly as a "snare"; so Zeus is paying back humans in kind.

How is this first woman a snare? The outstanding thing about her is that she looks exceedingly beautiful—we should think of Helen here—but that she hides a dangerous and destructive nature. Here is the description of her creation in the *Theogony*:

Straightaway in return for fire, he fashioned an evil for humans.
For the famous Hephaistos made from the earth
an image of a modest young maiden through the counsels of Zeus.
And the grey-eyed goddess Athena put a girdle on her and dressed her
in silver-white clothing; over her head she draped a veil,
beautifully made by hand, amazing to see.
And around her head Pallas Athena wrapped garlands
lovely, of new spring grass with blossoms. . . .
And wonder held the immortal gods and mortal men
when they saw this sheer trap, inescapable for men.

And from her is the race of female women,
from her is the deadly race and tribe of women.
A great bane, they live among mortal men,
not well-suited to destructive poverty, but suited for plenitude.
(*Theogony* 571–593)

This, then, is a story about the creation of gender. Before this first woman, evidently, all humans were male. (How they reproduced is not a question that the text asks, or answers.) From now on, however, reproduction will be sexual. Significantly, that mode of reproduction is always marked by deception: men are taken in by the woman's beauty, a beauty that hides her true nature. Two anxieties are at play here. First, we see the concern that men will not be able to control their own desires when faced with feminine beauty. Second, and equally important, is a fear that women are by nature greedy, that they consume, but do not produce, and this uncontrolled appetite is the thing that fundamentally defines them.

The uncontrollable appetite that characterizes femininity is more marked in the version of the story in the *Works and Days*. There, the woman is similarly created as beautiful on the outside, but her destructive interior is made even more explicit. At the end of her creation, the poet tells us, "And the guide Hermes, slayer of Argos, fashioned in her breast / lies and wheedling words, and a thieving nature" (*Works and Days* 77–78). In this story, moreover, her action suits her character. Pandora performs exactly one act in the narrative: she opens the lid on a jar, letting all of the evils out into the world, and closes the lid in time to save only one quality, that of hope. Later versions of this myth, in which Pandora lifts the lid on a box—explicitly violating of an injunction from her husband—are more familiar to most readers. In this earliest existing Greek version, however, the emphasis is not on her act as a transgression against an order, but rather on the fact that she is a *consumer*. The lid that she lifts is on a *pithos* jar, the type of jar that Archaic Greeks used to store up food, oil, and wine to feed on during the lean months before harvest. Here, Pandora's opening of the jar is an act of consumption and one that threatens the male householder.

It may seem that this has little to do with sex or sexuality, but I suggest that there is a careful correspondence created here. Just as Pandora presents a threat because she consumes food—that is, she does not control her appetite—the story contains a subtle message about women being unable to control their *sexual* appetites. As we have already seen, Pandora is slinky and seductive, posing a threat to men, who should know better than to be taken in by her looks. Later on in the *Works and Days*, the poet

speaks directly to the reader and warns him not to be fooled by a beautiful and sexy woman:

Do not let a woman with a tight dress deceive your mind,
Coaxing with charming words while she hunts for your *barn*.
Whoever trusts a woman puts his trust in a thief.
(*Works and Days* 373–375)

The anonymous woman's appetites are thus brought into close congruence. She cannot control her appetite for sex, but what that appetite hides is another, more dangerous appetite for food; it is up to the man to resist both (female) appetites and keep them both under control. Again, later in the poem, the poet talks about a woman's appetite for sex and the damage that it can do to a man:

For a man obtains nothing better than a wife,
if she is good, but then if she is bad, there is nothing more
horrible,
a glutton who, even though her husband is a strong man,
roasts him without fire and gives him over to an early old age.
(*Works and Days* 702–705)

Here again, the woman's sexual appetite is likened to an appetite for food, and the danger is that she will consume her husband's vital energy before its time.

Hesiod's poem, then, provides us with important evidence about the way the Greeks thought about the division of humanity into two genders. More important, it shows us how the gender of femininity is mapped directly onto a kind of sexual identity: women are defined by their inability to control appetites. They pose a risk to men specifically because men must resist their charms, thereby controlling both their own appetites and those of their wives.

THE CHARMS OF GREEK LOVE POETRY

From the seventh century onward, Greeks from different cities wrote some of the most striking love poetry in the Western tradition. Most of this poetry falls into the ancient genres of lyric and elegiac poetry, by which the Greeks and Romans meant that these poems were written in specific meters. Lyric poetry was so named because it was accompanied by music

played on the lyre. Elegiac poetry is written in a variant of the meter used for epic poetry. More important for modern readers, however, is the fact that lyric and elegiac poems are generally short, tend to treat intensely personal subjects, and evoke a strong emotional response. Though the traditions of lyric and elegiac poetry continue in the fifth century and beyond, the poetry of the sixth century carries an extraordinary vibrancy; it is little wonder that these early poets became canonical.

In this section, we will look at four Archaic poets. They all come from different parts of Greece, write in slightly different dialects, and have different approaches to writing the subject of love. With all such poetry, however, certain formal aspects create a particular relationship with the reader. Unlike epic poetry, in which an omniscient narrator speaks directly to us, much erotic poetry is written from the point of view of a smitten lover, a man (or woman, in the case of Sappho) who declares himself powerless in the face of his erotic desire. What is more, many of these poems are addressed to the beloved himself or herself. This creates the illusion that we are eavesdropping on a personal correspondence, as if we were reading a private love letter. The reader is not explicitly a part of the poem, but of course, we are always there. These are, in fact, not love letters, but poems meant to be read by us. We are positioned, then, as voyeurs into this erotic world, and part of the pleasure of reading these poems comes from the sensation of illicit access to secret pleasures.

As with epic poetry, however, it is important to remember that this portrayal of private pleasure is, nonetheless, a fiction. Too often, the love poems of Sappho or Anacreon have been read as unmediated outpourings of emotion, a kind of verse biography of their love lives. On the contrary, the function of these poems is to invest us, the readers, with an erotic experience through reading. Though these poems can and do tell us about the assumptions and expectations of the ancient Greeks, they cannot be taken as biographical fact.

THEOGNIS

Boy, do not wrong me—I wish to be dear to you still—understanding
this with noble grace.⁴

You will not pass by me with a trick, nor will you deceive me. Having
won, you have still more in the future,
but I will injure you as you flee from me, as once, they say the daughter
of Iasios, the Iasian maiden,
though she was ripe, spurned marriage with men, and fled. She girded
herself and she fulfilled fruitless deeds,

having shrunk from the home of her father, blonde Atalanta. And she
 lived in the high crowns of the mountains,
 fleeing from desirable marriage, the gifts of golden Aphrodite. But
 finally she knew, though refusing strongly.
 [see: But she knew completion, though refusing it strongly.]
 (Theognis 1283-1294)⁵

Theognis is a poet traditionally said to be from the city of Megara; like
 many early Greek poets, it is unclear whether his work was actually written
 by one man or is the product of a group of people writing in a particular
 style (referred to by modern scholars as the Theognid school). This also
 means that we cannot be sure of the date of any particular poem, though
 Theognis is said to have lived in the sixth century.

The content of the poems in the corpus of Theognis, however, forms a
 consistent thematic and poetic whole. The poems are addressed to a young
 man, Cyrnus, and form a kind of educational program. Many of the verses
 are not erotic at all, but concern various political and social concerns in
 the city of Megara, written from the point of view of an aristocrat. In some
 of the poems, however, it is clear that Cyrnus is represented as Theognis's
 beloved (*eromenos*), and Theognis's attempts to educate him are inextricably
 woven into their erotic relationship. As such, Theognis's poetry pro-
 vides us with one of our clearest examples of an aristocratic pederastic
 relationship.

In such a relationship, an older man befriends a younger man and edu-
 cates him in the ways of the world—erotic, political, and social. The poems
 of Theognis show a good deal of anxiety on two levels. On the first level,
 the poems are addressed to Cyrnus to convince him to remain with Theog-
 nis, his lover. The poet warns against trading his affections for those of a
 baser man. On the second level, however, these poems are concerned with
 maintaining the integrity of Theognis's and Cyrnus's social circle. Theog-
 nis does not want his beloved to fall in with the wrong crowd. The erotic,
 then, becomes a metaphor for the social: to spurn Theognis's affections
 (for someone else's) is also to betray the social circle to which Cyrnus be-
 longs. And that, in addition to causing personal pain to the poet, is bad
 politics.

The definition of a social circle is clearest in brief poems that make ref-
 erence to "our friends" (*philoî* in Greek), like the following:

Boy, you have destroyed my good thoughts for you with your wanton
 ways

and you have become a disgrace to our friends (*philoï*).
You refreshed me for a little while, but I have arrived
out of the storm and found anchorage as night came on.
(Theognis 1271–1274)

Again, we should note that there does not seem to be any criticism here of the pederastic relationship; there is nothing wrong with the “boy” sleeping with men. What is unacceptable to the poet is that the youth has been indiscriminate in his affections and has slept with men who are, apparently, not in their circle of *philoï*. At the same time, the relationship with the young man, now past, or at least in abeyance, was like a “storm” for the poet, a metaphor for the intensity of the erotic relationship. Most likely, the relationship was stormy specifically because of the boy’s indiscriminate “wanton ways,” my translation for a word that in Greek can refer to over-eating or indiscriminate sexual behavior.

Elsewhere, the people outside the circle of friends are seen as even more deliberate enemies:

Do not give up on your present friend, seeking another,
obeying the words of cowardly men;
often they will say empty things to me about you,
and about me to you; don’t listen to them.
You will take pleasure in the love that passed by earlier,
and you will no longer be the steward of the one that is arriving.
(Theognis 1238a–1242)

Here the “cowardly” men are *deïloï*, a word that can indicate a lack of courage, but also has connotations of lower social class, so Theognis’s advice is about more than just love. He is also concerned to advise the young man about his appropriate social station. The cementing of community works here on two levels at once. First, the poet suggests that those outside their social circle are unworthy and not to be trusted. They are an active threat to the speaker’s social group. At the same time, their lies threaten to destroy Theognis’s erotic relationship with the boy, to the boy’s disadvantage; in time, the boy will learn that the love he had (with Theognis) was superior, after it is too late.

Similar to these poems, but with a slightly different emphasis, are some pleading verses in which the poet warns the young man of the danger of spurning his lover. He is at the height of his physical attraction now, but soon, he will be too old to be pursued, and then he will know the tor-

ments of pursuing a flighty but beautiful boy. This theme will reverberate throughout Greek same-sex love poetry; it is beautifully presented in Theognis 1327–1334:

Boy, so long as you have a smooth cheek, I will never
stop praising, not if it is my fate to die.
It is something noble for you to give, and for me, it is not shameful
to ask, since I am in love. I beg you by your knees,
treat me with respect, beautiful boy, give me favor, or if ever you, too,
will arrive, needing the gift of violet-wreathed Aphrodite,
and you will chase after another, may the goddess grant that you
receive in return the very same words in response.

The beloved's era of attraction is clearly marked: "as long as you have a smooth cheek." The argument that the lover makes, moreover, is one that suggests reciprocity over time. One day, the boy himself will be a lover, and the poem ends with a wish that the boy receive exactly the answer then that he gives now.

We should also note, however, that the relationship thus defined is rigorously unsymmetrical. The speaker wants the boy to "give pleasure," but there is no suggestion that the pleasure would flow in the other direction. Moreover, the boy's motivations for giving this pleasure are perhaps not those we would expect: "respect me" is the poet's request. Theognis is quite cagey about how exactly the youth should show this respect. These poems are fairly decorous in their portrayal of love. In another epigram, the speaker hints at physical limits:

Boy, listen to me since you've mastered my thoughts; I will tell
no story that is not convincing to your heart, nor unpleasing.
But be bold to understand my words with your mind; you do not need
to do what does not sit well with your heart. (Theognis 1235–1238)

Here the speaker positions himself as a teacher, his beloved as a recalcitrant student. He promises that his teachings will not be unpleasant. In the last line, though, the emphasis shifts to what the beloved boy will *do* (Greek *erdein*). Just as the speaker's story will not be unpleasant, he assures the young man, neither will he cross the line of acceptable sexual behavior. But the speaker does not tell us what that line is.

There are hints in this poetry about such a love relationship creating a sense of shame, usually in the form of the speaker saying that there is no

shame in what he does. In 1327–1334 (given previously), the poet assures the young man that it is “noble” for him to give, and that for the speaker, “it is not shameful / to ask, since I am in love.” This implies that such a relationship could be shameful, outside the confines of the pederastic relationship. If the poet were a different kind of man, if he did not really love the boy, their relationship would, perhaps, be a more sordid one. But again, the speaker does not suggest that same-sex relations are shameful, but rather indiscriminate ones.

The lover in this kind of relationship is open to criticism himself, however, in that his lust for the youth implies a lack of self-control. Consider the following:

Alas! I love a boy with tender skin, who shows me off
to all his friends, even though I do not wish it.
But I will bear it, and have not hidden the many harms that I did not
want.
For I have shown that I was not mastered by a boy who is unseemly.
(Theognis 1341–1344)

The poem (as some modern editors have it) goes on to point out that even Zeus fell in love with Ganymede, so why should the speaker not give in to a similar desire? Here again, we see the same circle of friends that the poet has urged solidarity with in other poems, but in this case, the circle turns inward for a bit of good-natured ribbing. The youth possesses a certain kind of power here, embodied in his beauty. Because he is so good-looking (“tender-skinned” is an erotically charged description), he is able to lead the speaker around by the nose. He boasts a bit, showing off how he has tamed this older, sober, respectable teacher. And though the teacher does, clearly, feel some embarrassment, he puts a brave face on it: at least he was tamed by a beautiful boy. Such behavior, though embarrassing, is not shameful; it is rather that sense of embarrassment that a modern young man or woman might experience at the hands of his or her friends when in the early stages of romance.

With Theognis’s poems, then, there are always onlookers, always a circle of friends watching, teasing, approving, and participating. The poetry itself becomes a way of solidifying this social group: if the young man misbehaves (especially by consorting with men outside the circle), the poems act as a way to shame him into better behavior. If that fails, he can be excluded. The speaker himself alternately tries to win his love and console himself when that love is gone, but whatever he does, he does

in the watchful eye of his *philoî*. The education of Cynus, then, is not only represented in these poems, but rather, it is enacted by them. The poetry creates a community of readers whose behavior is consistent with the values that the poems espouse.

ANACREON

Once again Eros has struck me, like a bronze smith,
with a large axe and washed me in a wintry mountain stream.
(Anacreon 413)

Anacreon is said to have been born on the island of Teos, in the first quarter of the sixth century BCE. He lived and worked as a court poet, for both Polycrates of Samos and Hipparchos of Athens. His lyric poetry is written in the persona of a single speaker and was regarded in antiquity as among the finest of its kind.

Unlike Theognis, the poetry of Anacreon is not exclusively directed to a single young man, and it does not purport to have an educational function. Anacreon writes poems to both young men and young women, and his love poetry is characterized by strong (and sometimes graphic) metaphors like the one in the preceding fragment. Some of Anacreon's poems can be put in a particular context, that of the all-male symposium (on which, see the following discussion). Others are not so easily placed. Since most of Anacreon's poetry comes to us in fragments, bits of poetry quoted by later authors, it is often impossible to be sure of the exact context of the few lines we have. Nonetheless, Anacreon's imagery, particularly that describing the speaker's helplessness in the face of love, provides us with insight into Archaic Greek attitudes toward Eros, that most fickle of deities.

Anacreon is particularly known for his poems composed for the symposium. In Archaic and later Greece, upper-class men regularly got together at drinking parties known as symposia. The men drank wine, engaged in witty and sophisticated conversation, listened to poetry and song, and were entertained by professional female entertainers generally referred to as "flute girls." (Respectable women were not invited as members of the party.) To judge from numerous vases depicting these symposia, such parties were often suffused with eroticism. Older men gaze longingly at smooth-cheeked "boys," who either return the gaze or look absently elsewhere. Within the sexual system of ancient Greece, then, these parties were a place for the upper classes to meet eligible young men.

Several of the poems of Anacreon make reference to these symposia and indeed declare proper behavior there, such as 96d:

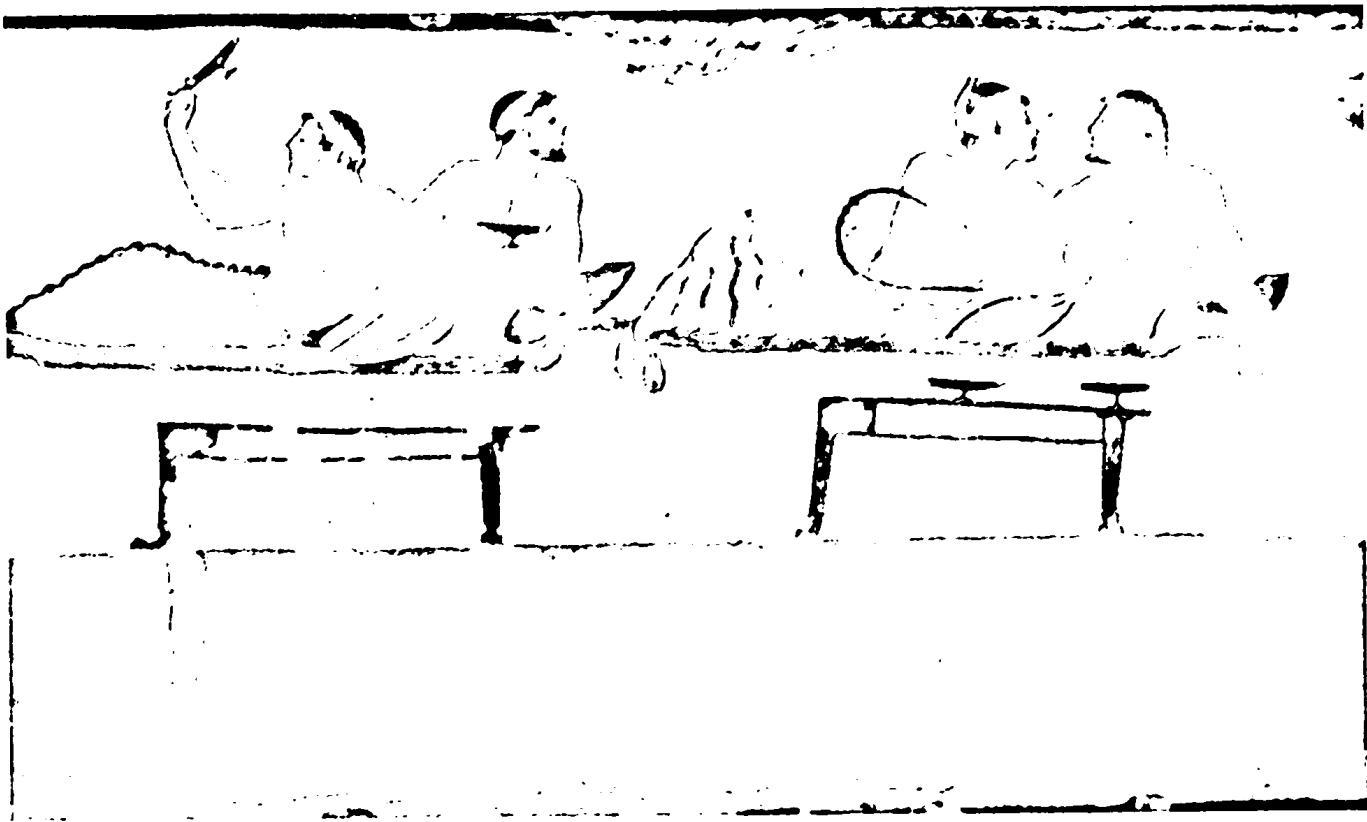


FIGURE 2.1

Greek wall painting from the Tomb of the Diver, Paestum, early fifth century BCE. Two couples recline on dinner couches. Each couple consists of an older bearded man and a young man with light hair on his cheeks. The older man in the center appears more interested in the other couple than in his own partner. Museo Archeologico Nazionale, Paestum, Italy. Photo taken by the author.

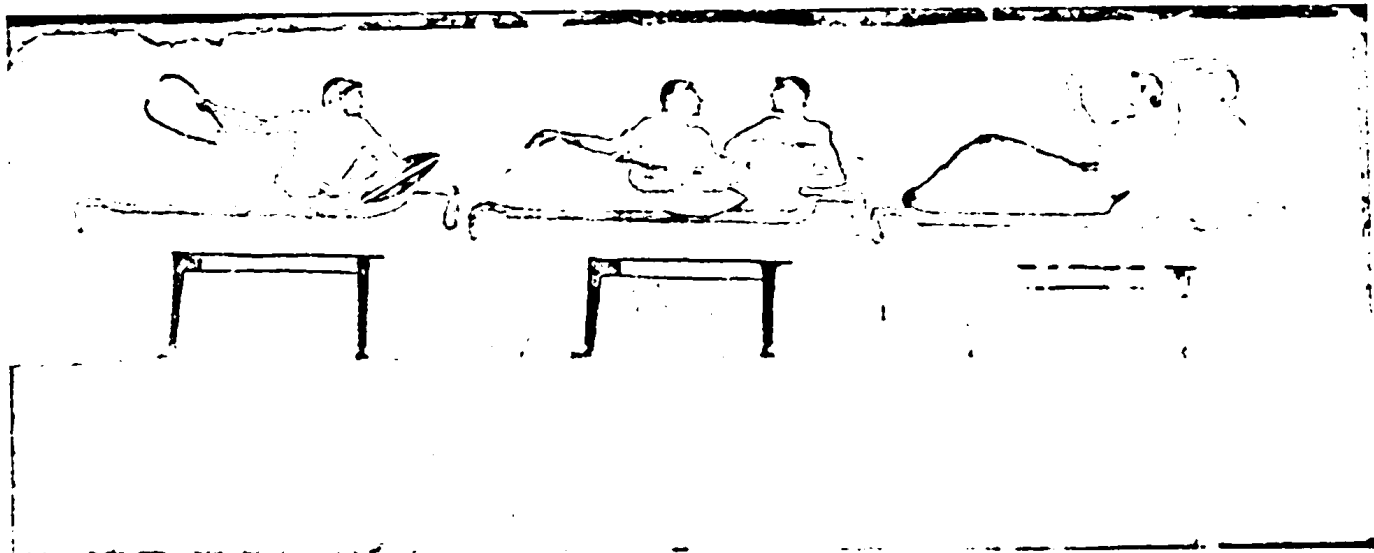


FIGURE 2.2

Greek wall painting from the Tomb of the Diver, Paestum, early fifth century BCE. Two couples recline on dinner couches. The young man to the far right plays the aulos; his partner throws his head back in a stylized indication of ecstasy. Museo Archeologico Nazionale, Paestum, Italy. Photo taken by the author.

I do not love the one who, drinking too much wine,
speaks of strife and tearful war,
but rather he who, mixing together the shining gifts of the Muses and
Aphrodite,
remembers seductive pleasantries.

The word I have translated as “seductive” in the last line is *eratos*, a word derived from Eros, the god of erotic desire. These lines, then, are about the kind of poetry that should be recited at a symposium: not, like Homer’s verses, heavy epic poems about war and strife, but rather poems that are in themselves pleasant and charming—poems about love. The person who does this successfully becomes the person whom Anacreon himself loves.

It is in this context that most scholars place a number of other poems, ranging from the simple to the more complex. In fragment 359, we see a charming depiction of the poet’s obsession with a young man named Kleobolos:

I lust after Kleobolos,
I am crazy for Kleobolos,
I gaze at Kleobolos.

The last line is something of an anticlimax, perhaps intentionally so. After declaring the strength of his feelings, the speaker, in the end, can do no more than look on and admire his beloved. He is stuck there, gazing but not acting despite his manic lust. His own powerlessness is enacted in the contrast between the strength of his feelings and his lack of any action beyond looking.

A more complex poem is addressed to an unnamed boy and is an early example of a poetic image that will be picked up by Plato in his dialogue the *Phaedrus*:

Boy, you who glance like a girl,
I look at you, but you do not notice,
not realizing that you hold the reins
of my soul. (Anacreon 360)

The lines are carefully crafted, and work in several registers at once. The boy is said to glance “girlishly” (*parthenion*), a word that carries connotations of innocence, a lack of guile. But then it is confusing to find that, though the speaker is looking at the boy, the boy does not notice, or per-

haps appears not to. If he is not noticing, at whom is he glancing modestly? Is the boy innocent, or merely coy? In any case, what the boy does not notice, or appears not to, is that he has enthralled the speaker of the poem. The image of “holding the reins” is one of control, mastery of a horse. As with much erotic poetry, this self-abasement by the speaker is both a real expression of the loss of control one feels in the face of erotic desire and mildly ironic. It is the boy who is presented as young, innocent, and unknowing; yet he is in control of the wise, worldly, and speaking poet. Even this image of erotic submission, moreover, is less straightforward than it might appear. Though the phrase “you hold the reins of my soul” certainly sounds decorous, it is also a bit naughty. Riding a horse is a common metaphor for having sex in Archaic and later Greek poetry. The poem, then, creates a tension between the graphic image that it calls up, that of the boy “riding” the speaker, and the sublime expression of the poet’s devotion to the boy. This tension is quintessential of Anacreon’s poetry, and it is what makes him such a brilliant poet. Eros always exists in a state of tension.

In the corpus of Anacreon’s work, we also find poems addressed to young women. We do not know if these are any more or less biographical than those addressed to young men, but in any case, Anacreon exhibits no conflict about writing poems in the voice of characters who desire young women as well as young men. Again, some of the fragments are so short as to defy interpretation, such as the line quoted by Athenaeus (a rhetorician from the second to third centuries CE, writing in Egypt), as an example of the power of thirst: “For you are a friendly girl toward strangers; since I am thirsty, allow me to drink” (Anacreon 389). One can easily imagine a context for this line that has nothing to do with the erotic, or one can read it as a somewhat crude come-on. Without more from the fragment, we will never know the meaning with any certainty.

One of Anacreon’s most famous poems, however, allows for no such ambiguity of intent, though its meaning has been much debated. Again, we do not know the context of the poem; it appears to be a love poem in which a (male) speaker tries to seduce a young woman:

Thracian filly, why do you look askance at me,
and flee heartless—do you think that I know nothing clever?
Know this, I would put the bit in your mouth beautifully,
and holding the reins I would turn you around the end post of the track;
but now you feed in the meadows, and you play, frisking lightly,
for you have no one skilled in horse riding to mount you.

(Anacreon 417)

As a heteroerotic attempt at seduction, these lines are not terribly subtle. An aspect that is clearer in the Greek than in translation, however, is the suggestion that the young woman move from a position of innocence to one of experience. At the moment, she is simply out frisking freely in a meadow, a paradigm for innocence about to be lost. The meadow is itself uncultivated, and her activity there is enjoyable but without purpose. The speaker offers to bring her into a world of culture, here represented by horse racing, where she will enjoy the experience of being ridden. The entire poem operates on this idea of transition to the world of experience, and nearly every line works as a double entendre in which sex equals knowledge and knowledge equals a submission to the speaker.

At the very least, then, we can say that Anacreon writes poems to both young men and young women, though again, we should remember that in none of these poems is the speaker to be securely identified with the poet. One point, however, is quite interesting about the poems addressed to young men and the poem addressed to the young Thracian woman. When Anacreon addresses a boy, or when he speaks of Eros, he tends to declare his utter helplessness in the face of his desire. We saw this in the poem about the boy who "held the reins" to the speaker's soul most clearly. Here, however, when the speaker wishes to seduce a young woman, he positions himself as the rider—he is the one in control, the one who holds knowledge that the beloved needs. In general, this relationship holds true for most male Greek lyric poets: helplessness before a boy, mastery before a young woman. The same is not quite true, as we will see, when we deal with the only female poet of whom we have significant fragments left: Sappho.⁶

We have one poem in which Anacreon is harshly critical of another man, and we might be tempted to see here a notion of sexual orientation, or perhaps sexual identity:

Before, he used to wear a ragged hat, a tightly tied hood,
and wooden dice in his ears, and a smooth skin
of an ox around his ribs,
the filthy wrapping of a poor shield, and he held company
with bread sellers and willing whores, the rogue Artemon,
finding a counterfeit life.
Many times he placed his neck in stocks, many times on the wheel,
many times he was flogged on the back with a leather whip, and his hair
and beard were plucked out.
But now he rides a woman's carriage wearing gold earrings,

the son of Cyce, and he carries an ivory parasol
just like a woman. (Anacreon 388)

The speaker would have us believe that this fellow Artemon is worthless, and at the end of the poem, he attacks him, in particular, for his womanish ways. Artemon's behavior is suspect, but in a manner consistent with the sexual system that I discussed earlier; that is, Artemon is not attacked for loving young men. In fact, the "willing prostitutes" of the second stanza could have been of either gender. He is attacked, rather, for violations of his gender role, both before and after his acquisition of wealth. Moreover, the attack on him is double. It is not merely that Artemon is an effeminate, but rather that his newfound ostentation is ridiculous to those who know his character from before. Whereas before he was a cheap effeminate, now he is a rich one; the reader recognizes with the poet that nothing fundamental about his character has changed. Artemon, then, can be said to have a sexual morphology, a non-normative gender role, and perhaps even a sexual identity. But unlike a modern homosexual man, he has no clear sexual orientation, and it is his gender role that is most strikingly criticized.

Anacreon, in brief, provides a lens through which we can see how elite Greek men thought about erotics. The poems present the somewhat fanciful and overblown declarations of helpless love for boys that characterized the erotic interaction of the symposium; the speaker's masterful, if amusing, attempt at seducing a young woman; and finally, the reassertion of proper masculinity and social class in the attack on a lowborn effeminate like Artemon. Anacreon is a proper aristocrat. For all that, his love poetry is clever, highly charged, and brilliantly constructed.

THE PROBLEM OF SAPPHO

A single sweet apple blushes on the topmost branch,
way up on the tip-top, but the apple gatherers do not notice it;
or rather, they notice, but they are not able to reach. (Sappho 105a)

No Archaic poet is more important for our understanding of ancient sexuality than Sappho, and no Greek poet has been so variously understood, or misunderstood. Though very little is certain about her life, Sappho is reported to have been born in the last quarter of the seventh century BCE. Of the nine books of poetry she is supposed to have written, we have a few hundred lines, and only one or two complete poems.⁷

Although Sappho wrote in various meters and genres, she is best known for her love poetry, in which the speaker expresses erotic desire for a number of named women. Sappho lived on the island of Lesbos, and it is from this island that we derive the modern word *lesbian*. As soon as one makes this observation, however, we are forced to point out that the ancient world did not make the same associations with Lesbos as we do. In fact, ancient Greek has a verb, *lesbiazo*, but in most instances, the specific meaning of that word is “to perform fellatio.” With one notable exception (discussed later), the women of Lesbos are not known for their single-sex attraction, but rather for a general enthusiasm for sex.

In fact, no contemporary of Sappho’s ever mentions her (poetic) desire for other women. It simply does not seem to be worthy of comment. Although we know of some comedies from the fourth century BCE that may have poked fun at Sappho’s sexual behavior, these works have been almost entirely lost. Not until the Roman period is Sappho’s homoerotic desire clearly made a problem, and then her behavior is likened to that of the *tribas*, or masculine woman. Sappho was seen by Greeks of the sixth and fifth centuries as remarkable, to be sure, but more as a female poet than as a homoerotic one. Within this context, the ancient readers regarded her as unusually skillful and her poetry as unmatched in beauty. Plato referred to her as “the tenth muse.”

Needless to say, the history of the reading of Sappho is complex and fascinating; I cannot do justice to it here.⁸ Every generation has invented its own Sappho and read her poetry in the light of that invention. In modern times, her so-called lesbianism (in the modern sense) at one time created a significant problem for classical scholars, and until quite recently a variety of strategies were used by scholars to rescue Sappho from the socially problematic category of lesbian. Some scholars fixated on later biographies of the poet, which suggested that Sappho fell in love with a man name Phaon and give birth to a daughter, though virtually none of the so-called facts in these biographies can be confirmed. Her sexuality thus assured, it was argued that her poems were addressed to women because she was taking on the persona of a male love poet.

Other strategies have been less ingenious, but equally debilitating. For Denys Page, who produced the standard philological edition of Sappho’s work, the operative strategy was to divorce Sappho’s work from her person. Though her poetry shows us her inclinations, he says, there is no evidence that she ever acted on them.⁹ While in general, Page’s principle is a sound one—it is, indeed, dangerous to assume that a poem’s speaker is to be identified with its author—in this case, the argument feels like special pleading. We have very few female poets; Sappho is clearly the most

important, and as it happens, she writes about desire for women, in a way that is distinct from the way men write about desire for women. It seems uncharitable at best, and homophobic at worst, to deny that Sappho ever enjoyed any erotic experience.

More devastating and more long-lasting than either of these strategies, however, was the invention of the image of Sappho as a schoolmistress.¹⁰ In this reading, the origin of which can be found at the end of the nineteenth century, Sappho's inclination for sex with young women was explained away as a kind of initiation rite. Young aristocratic women, it is supposed, were sent to Sappho, poet and etiquette expert, for finishing school before they entered the adult (and heterosexual) world of marriage. In this way, Sappho's love affairs were also likened to the male institution of pederasty, which, as we have seen, could have an educational function. Needless to say, there is no evidence for such a school, and reading the poems in such a context is distorting at best.¹¹

And yet, it is not easy to say how one *should* read Sappho. Her poetry is beautiful, deeply affecting, much imitated, and largely anomalous. The ancients seem not to have noticed the anomalies that so distract us; this, again, may simply be evidence that their sexual expectations were wildly different than ours. It is also possible, however, that the ancient Greeks are silent about Sappho's love for women because they *did* find it a problem and that the near-universal silence about it is the result of an unspoken conspiracy.¹² The simple fact is that Sappho is one of the very few sources from the ancient world that gives us an idea of how a woman might have thought of herself as a sexual subject. She does so, however, within the same kind of literary constraints that operate in the poetry of Anacreon or Theognis. We will do best, then, by trying to read her poetry in the context of other erotic poetry from the same period, and not by trying to make her fit with our ideas about either modern or ancient sexuality.

When we read Sappho in the context of other lyric poets, several striking features of her poetry emerge. Though it has sometimes been over-emphasized, her work presents a greater degree of mutual pleasure and affection between the lovers than the work of male poets. Sappho also demonstrates an exquisite ability to render personal helplessness in the face of passion. Though the same could be said of Anacreon, the difference in Sappho is that her helplessness does not depend on the willful power-brokering of her beloved; she simply *is* helpless when faced with a woman she desires, even if that woman is completely unaware of the watching poet. And finally, Sappho's poems represent, more than any other poet from the ancient world, the poignancy of desiring someone who is absent; Sappho's narrator concerns herself repeatedly with the idea of past plea-

asures, future pleasures, and lost companions. We almost never hear of pleasure in the present.

Sappho's poems often show a complicated narrative situation. Perhaps her most famous expression of erotic experience comes in the following lines (the fragment, we should note, is not complete):

That man looks like a god to me,
whoever sits across from you,
and listens close to your sweet talk
and desirable laughter, which sets aflutter
my heart in my breast.
For as I look at you quickly, so I can no longer speak
but my tongue breaks, silently, and thin
fire steals straight under my skin
and there is no sight in my eyes, and my ears hum,
a cold sweat holds me down, a trembling seizes
all of me, and I am paler than grass,
and I seem—to myself—little short of dying.
But all must be endured, since even a poor . . . (Sappho 31)

The description here of the speaker's incapacity is a remarkable poetic achievement, not least because of the way in which the poet takes us through such a variety of sensations: blindness, humming in the ears, simultaneously being on fire and cold with sweat. Eros, here, is a force that so overwhelms the process of sensation that it leaves the speaker unable to make sense. This, of course, is the most blatant of poetic conceits, since this expression of complete helplessness exists not only articulated but also in a complex and regular metrical scheme. There are two Sapphos here: one who appears to speak not to us, but to her beloved, about her inability to speak; and another who presents to us with clinical and metrical precision the symptoms of that desire.

Perhaps even more remarkable, and more problematic, however, is the narrative situation that is set up in the beginning lines of the poem. With the first line, it looks initially as if the narrator is going to write a poem to, or at least about, a man. This man is given conventional, but high, praise: he looks like a god. But in the next line, it turns out that the speaker has no interest in this man—if there even is a man—but rather in the “you” whom the poem addresses, the you who sits across from that man whispering sweet nothings to him. The idea of a male lover has been called up only to be made dazzlingly irrelevant, an outsider to the love relationship that the rest of the poem will explore.

In the history of this poem, a vast amount of ink has been spilled trying to pin down a historical moment that the narrative could be describing; critics have, in fact, been obsessed with the identity of the man. But as John Winkler pointed out some years ago, the man in the poem is not a particular person.¹³ The pronoun that introduces him in the second line, which I have translated “whoever,” is used to indicate a general situation. Whoever happens to sit across from the “you” of the poem is the one who looks like a god—not, however, by any virtue of his own. He is generic male. He looks like a god because he entertains “you.” In this regard, the poem is also a brilliant bit of erotic rhetoric. What appears to be a praise of “your” boyfriend turns out to be lavish praise of “your” erotic appeal. What could be more seductive than that?

On another level, however, the crucial aspect of this poem is the uncrossed distance between the speaker of the poem and her erotic object. As far as we can tell, the “you” of the poem is completely unaware of the speaker. If the man to whom she is supposed to speak and sweetly laugh is generic, then she, likewise, is not actually aware of the situation described; rather, she exists only in the speaker’s imagination, and she may be only a way to express the effects of Eros on the speaker. Unlike the young men of Anacreon’s poems, however, she is not deliberately tormenting the speaker of the poem, and there is no intentional exercise of erotic power. Rather, the poem is an expression of a purely one-sided desire; what the response of the “you” in the poem will be remains outside the experience of reading the poem.

Some other fragments of Sappho are in a less complete state but suggest actual erotic experience, though not in the present. Among the most beautiful is fragment 94 (I have marked gaps in the text with ellipses):

... and frankly I wish I were dead.
 She left me as she wept
 much and she said this to me.
 “Alas how terribly we have suffered,
 Sappho, indeed unwilling I am leaving you.”
 “Farewell, go and remember
 me, for you know how we cared for you.
 But if not, I wish to remind you
 ... and we endured lovely things
 For with many wreaths of violets
 and roses and crocus
 ... you placed by me,
 and many garlands woven

of flowers you placed
around a soft neck
and with much oil of
myrrh . . .
you anointed and for a queen
and on a soft bed
the gentle . . .
you would satisfy desire for . . .
and again someone . . . not any
shrine nor . . .
where we stayed away
nor grove . . . dance
. . . rattling

As the reader can readily see, the fragment is in such poor condition that it is difficult to know what is going on. The images, however, are more sensual in their way than anything we have seen from the male poets. Sappho pays attention to the softness and suppleness of the young women's bodies. The poem describes a scene that affects sight, touch, smell, and even hearing. Scented oil, wreaths of flowers, and soft necks—as here—are all fairly common in her poetry.

More important than all of this, however, is the narrative situation that appears in the first few lines. Though even this is not entirely clear, it appears that a young woman is speaking to Sappho just before leaving her company. She does not want to leave and claims to have “suffered” much. Sappho responds by reminding her how much she, Sappho, has cared for her in the past, in the process using a compound of the same verb that I have translated as “suffered,” literally, “and we suffered lovely things.” Sappho then enumerates these past pleasures as a way of bringing them physically into the present. The young woman who goes away will carry with her these past delights into her new situation, whatever that is. The poem, then, highlights the tension between present sadness at parting and past delight in company and brings the two forcibly together.

A similar technique is used in another, similar fragment, number 96:

. . . Sardis . . .
many times holding her thoughts here,
as . . . we . . .
you like a well-known
goddess, and she especially enjoyed your song.
But now she is outstanding among Lydian

women as when, after the sun sets,
the rosy-fingered moon
outshines all the stars; and the light
spreads over the salt sea
and over the many-flowered fields;
and the dew is poured out beautifully, and the roses
bloom and the delicate chervil
and the flowering melitote.
But wandering much, she remembers gentle
Atthis with desire,
and consumes her delicate heart over your fate.

Again, we must extrapolate a dramatic situation between the speakers. It appears that the speaker of the poem is consoling Atthis over the loss of a mutual friend, who has gone to Lydia. This consolation again makes use of memory as a way to survive the tragedies of passion. First, the speaker reminds Atthis of how their friend used to enjoy Atthis's company, and especially her poetry. We are then taken on an imaginative flight in which the missing young woman's life is described, using familiar images from epic and erotic poetry. Then memory is called up again, but this time in the other direction: the speaker suggests that the missing young woman is herself remembering Atthis and longing for her. Thus the speaker becomes a bridge between the two other women, each of whom experiences (again) her love for the other through memory.

Significantly, when the speaker describes the missing young woman, the images that she uses are deliberately feminine. Particularly striking is the image of the "rosy-fingered moon." The adjective *rosy-fingered* is familiar from Homeric epic, where it is inevitably used to describe the sun at dawn. The sun, however, is generally masculine in Greek thought (though admittedly the dawn, who is described as "rosy-fingered" is female). Here, the young woman is compared not to the rising light of day, but to the moon — significantly, a feminine noun and perceived as a female entity — in her brilliance. The purpose of the adjective *rosy-fingered* can only be to call up, and then deny, the idea of masculine epic poetry. This is a female poem, about female desire and experience.

Both of the poems described previously suggest a community of women who have shared erotic experiences with one another; it is perhaps on the strength of these two fragments, primarily, that the idea of Sappho's school for young women was devised. But we need not postulate Sappho's finishing school to imagine a circle of women who shared love and poetry together. More important, I think, are the tone and feel of these poems.

They are poems of consolation, and they suggest both mutual pleasure and mutual care. We do not see here the kind of male-female power dynamic of Anacreon's "Thracian filly" poem, or even of the bartering for sexual favors that underlies so many of the poems addressed to young men. At the risk of a dangerous essentialism of gender, Sappho's poems appear to represent a different, feminine, mode of erotics.

Before we are lulled into a sense of joy about this supposedly feminine, cooperative erotic experience, however, it would be wise to consider the only complete poem that we have from Sappho, fragment 1. In it, what looks initially like a reciprocal relationship of desire turns out to be rather closer to the masculine model:

Lovely-robed Aphrodite,
crafty-weaving child of Zeus, I beg you,
do not tame my spirit with pains
or anguish, queen,
but come here, if ever before
you heard my voice from a distance
and listened, and leaving the house
of your father, you came
having yoked your golden chariot.
And the beautiful swift sparrows led you,
over the dark earth, swiftly whirling their wings
through the middle atmosphere,
and straightaway you arrived. But you, blessed one,
with a smile on your immortal face
asked what again I suffered and why again
I was calling,
and what exactly I want to happen
with my crazy heart. "Whom again do I persuade
to lead you into her friendship? Who, Sappho,
is doing you wrong?
For if indeed she flees, swiftly she will pursue;
if she does not receive gifts, still she will give them;
and if she does not love, swiftly she will love
even if she does not wish to."
Come to me again now, and free me from harsh
sorrow, and whatever my heart desires to happen,
make it happen. And you yourself
be my ally.

Once again, we see a complicated narrative situation. The poem begins with Sappho calling on Aphrodite for help. She then reminds Aphrodite of previous instances when Aphrodite had answered such a prayer, and quotes, in direct speech, the goddess's words from one such instance. Aphrodite, we must notice, is a bit sharp with Sappho, calling to attention the repeated nature of her prayers, and asking, in brief, "What is it *this time*?" The poem ends with Sappho repeating her request, asking that Aphrodite be her battle ally (Greek *summachos*) again in yet another erotic conquest.

In Sappho's quotation of the goddess's past visit, Aphrodite reportedly made a series of promises to Sappho, and these promises have been read as evidence of reciprocal desire: if she flees, she will pursue; if she rejects gifts, she will give them; and so on. It seems here as if the rigorous one-sided nature of desire in the male poets is not so for women. Sappho's beloved can, in this reading, turn the tables and pursue. In such an interpretation of the poem, women's desire is less hierarchical than men's, their roles more fluid. Admittedly, this reversal of roles will require some compulsion on the part of Aphrodite, but it is nonetheless possible.

An interpretation of the poem by Anne Carson, however, suggests that this is a mistaken reading altogether.¹⁴ Carson argues that this reversal of roles is not going to happen *now*; it is not that this unnamed woman whom Sappho pursues will turn about and pursue Sappho. Indeed, the poem does not indicate that the object of her affections will be Sappho; it does not say who it will be at all. Rather, this poem is parallel to those works by male poets who tell young men that they had better hurry up and enjoy the lover's offer now, before they find that they are too old to be erotic objects and find themselves in the harsh position of offering gifts to other beautiful young men (see Theognis 1327–1334, given previously). In Carson's reading, Aphrodite's promise is simply that of age. She tells Sappho, simply, that if some beautiful young thing is fleeing her now, the time will come when that beloved object will have to pursue, and then she, too, will understand the pain that comes with asking and not receiving.

This second interpretation has on its side considerable philological support and has the further advantage of placing Sappho's poem in the context of contemporary love poetry. Though I am sorry to lose the idea of a mutually desiring lesbian couple, poetically enacted by Sappho, I find Carson's reading compelling. In this poem, at least, the experience of Eros is still one-sided, defined by power and all too short.

I conclude this chapter, then, by asking the crucial question, is Sappho a lesbian, in the modern sense of the word? The answer can only be am-

bivalent, and that ambivalence marks the divide between our modern erotics and that of the Archaic Greeks. If by *lesbian* we mean simply that Sappho is a woman who loves women, and that her expression of desire for those women provides evidence of a less hierarchical, more mutual form of desire than that expressed by male poets, the answer is yes. But we still have very little evidence that Sappho's desire for women was thought of as a *different kind* of desire than that of men for women, or women for men, or men for young men. And there is no solid evidence that Sappho or other women from Lesbos were thought of as belonging to a particular sexual *type*. Sappho may have a sexual orientation, but to the ancients, her poetry does not seem to have suggested a sexual identity or a sexual morphology.

There is one exception to this rule, and it is especially troubling because it is, like so much of our evidence, unique. Anacreon has one other poem that suggests that women from Lesbos were, in our sense, lesbian. He writes,

Again golden-haired Eros strikes me
with a purple ball, and calls me to play
with the girl with the fancy sandals.
But she, since she is from well-built
Lesbos, finds fault with my hair
(since it is white) and gapes
at another (girl). (Anacreon 358)¹⁵

What exactly do the words "since she is from well-built Lesbos" mean? And how, exactly, does the speaker's white hair come into it, to say nothing of the fancy sandals?¹⁶ The poem seems littered with irrelevant references and is almost as likely to refer to a preference, among Lesbian women, for young partners as for female ones. Nonetheless, we must admit that here, if only here, we may have a contemporary reference to a Lesbian woman's preference for women, and perhaps a criticism of that preference. This is hardly a sexuality in the modern sense of the word, but it does suggest the idea of a sexual orientation coupled with a sexual identity. This poem, then, lends support to the idea that the Greeks might, despite their near-universal silence on the subject, have been made anxious by women who had no erotic use for white-haired old men.